Setting Goals That Work: Performance Management for Small Teams

Small teams often assume performance management is something only large corporations do. In practice, a simple and consistent approach helps a ten-person business as much as a thousand-person one.

Review date: _____ Reviewed by: _____

Key points

• Clear goals matter more than complex forms.

• Regular conversations beat an annual review.

• Train managers to give feedback, because a system is only as good as the people using it.

Start with a few clear goals

Each person should be able to answer three questions: what am I responsible for, what does good look like, and how will it be measured. Three to five goals is plenty.

- ☐ Specific and written down
- ☐ Linked to what the business needs
- ☐ Measurable or observable
- ☐ Reviewed and updated as priorities change

Talk often, review formally twice a year

A short monthly conversation keeps goals alive and surfaces problems early. Add a more formal review every six months to look at results, strengths and development needs.

Give feedback people can use

Be specific, timely and balanced. Describe what you saw, the effect it had and what you would like to see next. Avoid vague comments such as "try harder".

Connect performance to support

If someone is struggling, look first at clarity, resources and training before assuming attitude. Where performance still does not improve, follow a fair and documented process.

Keep it light

A one-page template, a calendar reminder and a manager who follows through will take you further than an elaborate system nobody uses.

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